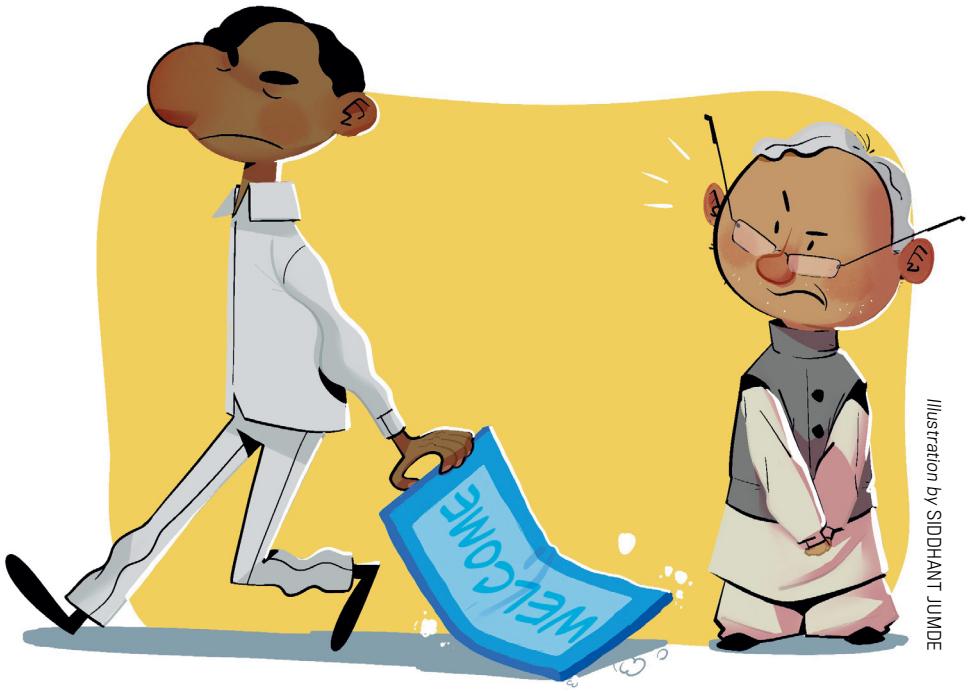


Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

GLASSHOUSE

CONGRESS-MUKT ALLIANCE

In August 2022, when Bihar chief minister Nitish Kumar left the BJP to join hands with the Rashtriya Janata Dal and Congress, Telangana CM K. Chandrashekar Rao (KCR) had come calling to Patna and even addressed a joint press conference with his Bihar counterpart, promising a grand opposition unity. Five months later, on January 18, when KCR held a mega public meeting at Khammam in Telangana, several Opposition leaders such as Arvind Kejriwal, Pinarayi Vijayan, Akhilesh Yadav and D. Raja attended. But not Nitish. Word is, the Bihar CM was not even invited because he has been working for an Opposition alliance that includes the Congress, an idea that does not amuse KCR.

Meghalaya-bound

West Bengal chief minister **Mamata Banerjee** seems to have given up on Tripura, which is going to the polls on February 16. The Trinamool Congress chief is focusing more on neighbouring Meghalaya where her party poached almost the entire Congress unit and is projecting former Meghalaya CM Mukul Sangma as the TMC face. While Mamata is likely to hold a rally in Tripura on February 7, she has already visited Meghalaya twice, even though the state goes to the polls 11 days after Tripura. Also boosting the TMC's confidence in Meghalaya is the fact that Prashant Kishor's I-PAC is running the election campaign.



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THE WORST OF TIMES



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The Union minister of state **Ashwini Kumar Choubey** is going through a rough patch. He wanted the power plant being built in his Lok Sabha constituency Buxar in Bihar ready by the 2024 general election, so that he could flaunt it as an achievement. But the farmers' agitation put a spanner in the works. Recently, when he went to show solidarity with them, one of them threw pebbles at him asking where he was earlier. Choubey then went on a *maun vrat* (vow of silence) at the city's Ambedkar Chowk. Later that evening, opposition leaders washed the Ambedkar statue. Meanwhile, his son Arjit Shaswat was defrauded of Rs 8.29 lakh by a cyber thug promising to get him a Toyota Fortuner cheap. Abuse is all he gets when Arjit calls the goon now, not his money.

Kaushik Deka** with **Amitabh Srivastava**, **Romita Datta**, **Pushyamitra** and **Anilesh S. Mahajan

Saffron News

The Tamil Nadu BJP is planning to start its own TV newschannel to counter the narrative Surya TV has set for the DMK and Jaya TV for the AIADMK. The existing right-of-centre Malayalam channel, Janam TV, has been asked to start operations in TN. Janam has been pushing the BJP-RSS narrative in Kerala and gained popularity during the Sabarimala controversy. The RSS and BJP-backed business houses in Chennai and Bengaluru have been asked to provide the initial capital for the channel's expansion. It is slated to launch on April 13, the Hindu new year, when BJP state unit chief **K. Annamalai** will start his walkathon.



MISSING THE BUS FOR THE TRAIN

At an executive committee meeting in Durgapur recently, **Sunil Bansal**, Mangal Pandey and Amit Malviya, senior BJP leaders in charge of the party's expansion in the state, pulled up the local unit. Towards the evening, when the top leaders entered the hall where the meeting was being held, it was half empty. An exasperated Bansal and Pandey agreed that the Bengal assignment, with the current crop of leaders, was by far the toughest they had faced. An embarrassed Sukanta Majumdar, the state BJP president, tried covering up saying that most leaders had a train to catch. Unimpressed, the Bengal minders said that if things continued like this, the party would miss the bus—coming to power in the state.



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR